and the Authority. Stakeholders can now view and verify their allotments in real-time, enabling swift implementation, reducing room for discrepancies. This streamlining of processes, with built-in transparency and accountability, sets a precedent for large-scale event management.

Yet, even with all this AI wizardry at hand, orchestrating an event as sprawling as it is intricate in its details is a herculean challenge. All the entwined strings finally pass to the hands of Vijay Kiran Anand, a clean-cut, 2009 cadre IAS bright spark who's been designated Kumbh Mela Officer and District Magistrate overseeing what is temporarily (for four months) the state's 76th 'district'. His mandate extends far beyond logistics. There are grievances and disputes over land and resource allocations, often fuelled by ego clashes between religious factions. Maintaining harmony and managing the often-conflicting demands of competing congregations and dharmic bodies is a task that demands equal parts diplomacy and a cool head. "We have expanded the mela area from 3,200 hectares in 2019 to 4,000 hectares and increased the number of sectors from 22 to 25. Yet, the demand for land has only surged, with everyone expecting more than what they got last time," says Mela District ADM Vivek Chaturvedi.

Epic Logistics

To streamline allocations, the administration prioritised *akhada*s, followed by other traditional groups like the Dandi Baada (ascetics bearing the 'Brahma danda'), the Acharya Baada of the Ramanuja branch, and Khak Chowk, a historic section that houses hundreds of Vaishnav *mahant*s and *mandaleshwar*s. Then came organisations with longstanding participation and, finally, verified new entrants. The minimum area allotted is traditionally decided and depends on the shore area left by the Ganga. A tricky variable there and, sure enough, nature proved to be in no mood to help. High water levels, taking longer than usual to recede to the threshold flow of 7,000 cusecs, delayed things. Help had to be sought from IIT Guwahati for 'dressing' (dredging) the riverbed, ensuring a channelised flow and reclaiming more shore area. It's on Anand to remain the calm, all-seeing eye in the centre of this blurry storm of digital mapping and concrete logistics, high waters and high dudgeon.

All that is just the prepping. Now comes the job of managing the moving millions, which needs even more razor-sharp attention. Central here is an AI-powered panopticon: the Integrated Command and Control Centre (ICCC) oversees this entire buzzing sprawl through an all-pervasive web of 2,700 CCTV cameras, drones and water surveillance systems. Its real-time monitoring will be key to swift emergency response, proactive decongestion and security. To enhance navigability, the Authority has partnered with Google to integrate into its maps all key landmarks: ghats, toilets, food courts, pontoon bridges, emergency services. The Kumbh app and website promise more user-friendliness with a multilingual chatbot,



ARTIFICIAL EYES Police technicians monitor vehicular and pilgrim movement in a 24/7 control room set up for surveillance of Prayagraj and the Kumbh township

The job of keeping millions safe, and moving, is with an integrated command centre that maintains a 24/7 vigil on this entire sprawl

SahaAlyak, which can address visitor queries in 11 languages. QR code-based services for ticketing, navigation and emergency assistance will help create seamless logistics, allowing pilgrims to focus on their spiritual journey. Parking, a challenge that usually multiplies by several orders of magnitude, has also been reimagined. There's space for 550,000 vehicles at any time at the 102 designated parking lots spanning 1,850 ha. All are outfitted with Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) systems to ensure quick entry and exit. Keeping an eagle eye will be 50,000-plus security personnel aided by drones, robotic buoys and all their AI tools. The ICCC will keep critical zones under constant surveillance. Fire curtains, fire gels and rapid response teams are on standby.

For those seeking a premium experience, whether international visitors or the desi beau monde, there are three separate tent cities. These elite setups, on a luxury gradient from around Rs 10,000 to over Rs 1 lakh per night, are the fruit of public-private partnerships. A range of other fancy, cottage-style 'villages' and VIP retreats are luring those who prefer their spirituality with gourmet dining, yoga and air-conditioning in January. As preparations reach their zenith, the city of Prayagraj (formerly Allahabad) stands adorned, its ghats gleaming, its waters sanc-